

Paris and Berlin's plan to fix EU foreign policy

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【メール原文】

Presented by AMD By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur — excited to be back with you after a great summer break. ICE COLD ON THE EU: Icelan

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur — excited to be back with you after a great summer break.

ICE COLD ON THE EU: Icelanders' rejection of restarting EU membership talks is a setback for Brussels' hopes of demonstrating the bloc's appeal to wealthy countries. A Yes vote would have been "an endorsement of Europe's attractiveness in the world," said an EU official granted anonymity to discuss the vote ahead of the referendum. The bit they didn't say out loud: No makes the opposite point. "It's like being rejected by someone you haven't even asked out," another EU official said of the result.

What now: Prime Minister Kristrún Frostadóttir said yesterday that her government will respect the result and put the issue to rest for the remainder of her term in office. Spokespeople for the Commission and European Council President António Costa stressed that Iceland remains a close EU partner despite the result. Meanwhile, the populist right was celebrating, with Marine Le Pen and Nigel Farage crowing about the No win on X.

In today's Playbook:

- The EU and Germany plan to hit back at Russia over hybrid attacks. Playbook has the details.
- Time runs out tonight for countries seeking to unlock EU funds. Hungary's bid is touch-and-go.
- Faces in the crowd: Kaja Kallas, Ursula von der Leyen, Kajsa Ollongren, Friedrich Merz, Maxime Prévot, Péter Magyar, Dubravka Šuica, Wopke Hoekstra and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick break down what Iceland's No vote means for the EU.

****A message from AMD: Open standards, interoperability, and supplier diversity will be the cornerstones of Europe's AI future. They drive innovation and choice, strengthen resilience, and provide opportunities to adopt and integrate novel technologies and new capabilities. Read how open technology stack drives choice across hardware, software and deployment models as the EU seeks to build sovereign AI capabilities.****

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — A NEW FRANCO-GERMAN PITCH TO OVERHAUL THE EEAS: Kaja Kallas, the EU's chief diplomat, would gain far-reaching powers to coordinate the European Commission's external-facing policy units, including on migration and development aid, under proposals being put forward by Paris and Berlin.

Europe's two powerhouse capitals are driving efforts to overhaul the European External Action Service (EEAS), the EU's 15-year-old foreign policy branch, as raw power politics, AI and budget constraints force a root-and-branch rethink.

The EEAS has suffered in a turf war with Ursula von der Leyen's Commission — while a French discussion paper earlier this year floated the option of bringing it completely under the Commission's authority.

The new paper is an attempt to steady the ship by boosting Kallas's role while recognizing that much of the real power to conduct foreign policy lies with the Commission.

Indeed, the proposals also foresee weakening the EEAS somewhat by moving some of its 5,000 staff and functions into the Commission amid pressure to slash the EU's long-term budget, according to three diplomats who spoke to Playbook and Hans von der Burchard.

The Franco-German paper will be in focus as EU foreign ministers gather tomorrow in Wicklow, Ireland. Not everyone is pleased: "A big institutional change right now is not realistic," said one of the EU diplomats, who ruled out any major reforms before the end of von der Leyen's second term in 2029.

Yes, and ... ? "Let's face it ... EU foreign policy only works if Member States want it," an EU official wrote to Playbook. "Shifting some teams from the EEAS to the Commission won't fix the Middle East or stop Russia's war."

Further: "The EU would have more leverage globally if we'd better align the tools we have — from diplomacy to visa policies, trade, aid and EU missions — in pursuit of European interests. The HRVP can provide that strategic direction, given her link to the Council."

Meanwhile ... Kallas has sent capitals a brief questionnaire seeking their views and plans to make some "initial proposals" this week, per the EU official. The five "guiding questions" seek feedback on how: 1) the EU can become a more "strategically assertive global foreign actor"; 2) the EEAS can get more value from its 145 delegations; 3) it can deliver on its treaty mandate; 4) it can streamline its institutional setup with the Commission and Council; and 5) it can contribute more effectively to leaders' discussions.

But the HRVP wants to wait until her new leadership team, including incoming Secretary-General Kajsa Ollongren, is in place before making big moves, the EU official said.

The bottom line: The EEAS faces a major challenge to prove its value as leaders including German Chancellor Friedrich Merz push to slash the EU's long-term budget (MFF). Some say that debate can wait. Paris and Berlin are suggesting it can't.

BIG AND BREAKING

VON DER LEYEN'S LEGACY: Zoya Sheftalovich drills into the six issues that will define the rest of Ursula von der Leyen's time in office — including reversing Europe's economic decline, pushing back against Donald Trump and defending Ukraine.

TRADING FIRE: The U.S. struck Iran for the first time in a month , targeting two rocket launchers it said were preparing to mine the Strait of Hormuz; Tehran responded by firing at American bases in Jordan.

THE NEW OIL? Petroleum may still rule the energy markets, but surging power demand is turning electricity prices into a political flashpoint across the U.S. and Europe, POLITICO's Benjamin Storrow reports .

Go deeper: Sign up for Surge , POLITICO's new daily global newsletter tracking how the worldwide explosion in electricity and power demand is reshaping the intersection of politics, policymaking and industry. Surge will explore how similar stresses are emerging simultaneously across countries, states and industries, often with very different political implications. It launches this evening at 7 p.m.

HITTING BACK AT MOSCOW

BRUSSELS READIES A RESPONSE TO HYBRID ATTACKS: The EU is getting ready to pummel Russia with new sanctions as Germany plans to formally blame Moscow for an attempted drone attack in Leipzig, as reported by POLITICO and Welt am Sonntag (both of which are owned by Axel Springer) over the weekend.

Message for Putin: The upcoming sanctions list, one of the biggest since the start of Russia's war against Ukraine, aims to show Moscow that Europe will not be cowed by escalating hybrid threats — and comes alongside bilateral measures being prepared by Berlin, according to three EU diplomats directly aware of its contents.

Mega-list: While Germany looks beyond traditional measures such as expelling diplomats, the EU plans to target some 1,600 individuals and entities as part of a draft sanctions list currently being reviewed by EU capitals, according to one of the diplomats.

The line is hardening: The list, which the diplomats said should be finalized by an October gathering of EU leaders, was sent to capitals earlier in the summer, but it could harden resolve in capitals like Berlin.

"The strategy is to fire on all cylinders," an EU diplomat told Playbook. "We are using every possible ... regime. The message for Moscow is that we are not backing down."

Stand back: Russia's deadly attacks on Ukraine's cities and its worsening threats against its Kyiv's allies are dominating the agenda this rentrée. One senior EU official saw fit to tell journalists in recent days: "The European [security] services do not see any risk of attack on European countries."

Nevertheless, EU defense and foreign ministers will discuss the hybrid threats when they meet in Ireland this week for FAC defense and Gymnich meetings, along with the need to bolster Ukraine's air defense, how to fund Kyiv in the coming years and EEAS reform.

More cover for Ukraine: Countries that have not significantly contributed interceptors to Ukraine, such as Greece and Spain, will face pressure at this week's meetings, according to the EU diplomat.

The funding fight: A group of countries including the Netherlands and Sweden will also bring up using Russia's frozen assets to fund Ukraine from next year, arguing that Kyiv's funding needs remain acute — though Belgium's position on that hasn't changed.

STUBB SPEAKS: Finland's President Alexander Stubb urged the EU to be vigilant but measured in response to hybrid attacks, telling Paul Ronzheimer of the Axel Springer Global Reporters Network: "I think it's very important that we react to these things with a clear and a rational mind." (POLITICO is also part of the Global Reporters Network.)

Stubb played down German warnings that Russia could strike a NATO country by 2029. "I just don't see the evidence or the facts for that," the Finnish president said, adding that it'd be too risky for Moscow to take on the alliance. He also said China's foreign minister had assured him Beijing wouldn't allow Russia to use nuclear weapons — "and I think that's a pretty good deterrence."

MEANWHILE, IN MOSCOW: The Russian military is preparing for a significant offensive against Ukrainian energy infrastructure, the defense ministry said on Sunday.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Belgium's Foreign Minister Maxime Prévot last week summoned U.S. Ambassador Bill White after he mocked the country's health minister in a social media post. But what happens when an ambassador is summoned? First, a formal diplomatic note (known as a note verbale) is sent to the relevant country's embassy telling the representative to attend a meeting at the relevant ministry, at which the reprimand will be issued. There is of course a large element of political theater at work, as ministries could easily just call ambassadors.

THE RRF CLOCK RUNS OUT

PENCILS DOWN: Countries that haven't finished the reforms necessary to unlock millions in loans and grants from the EU's post-Covid Recovery and Resilience Facility run out of time tonight — and it's unclear whether Hungary will make it.

No extra time: The Commission told capitals that actions taken to meet milestones and targets after the Aug. 31 deadline won't count toward unlocking the cash, an official told Zoya Sheftalovich. Countries have until Sept. 30 to submit their final payment requests, after which the Commission will assess whether the changes have been enough to get the money.

All eyes are on Hungary: Prime Minister Péter Magyar's government has been ramming through reforms, as it desperately wants around €10 billion in RRF funding. A Commission official said Budapest was working "until the last minute," and it won't be clear whether it has succeeded until Brussels starts marking its homework next month.

ICYMI — Romania flew the white flag, with the president acknowledging on Friday that it will lose out on €770 million after failing to complete key reforms.

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3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

WHY ICELAND'S NO CAMP WON: From fishing rights to worries about an island country's sovereignty, Lara Jäkel gets into the real reasons why Iceland rejected a new chance at EU membership .

GERMANY'S MOMENT OF PERIL: This month's state elections could trigger Germany's gravest political crisis in decades and bring down Friedrich Merz's embattled government, John Kampfner argues.

BURNHAM LOOKS ABROAD: Andy Burnham has spent his first weeks as British PM talking about domestic priorities, but now faces a towering in-tray of foreign policy challenges — including how to handle Donald Trump.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny spells mixed with thundery showers. High of 20C.

HOW THE GREEKS WON COFFEE: Eliza Gkritsi stirs the pot with a deep dive into how Greek coffee shops conquered the EU quarter, winning favor among eurocrats and lobbyists alike and catching the Italians off-guard.

Tell Playbook what you think: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked for your favorite coffee spot in Brussels — and what you like to order. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

SPOTTED: At Moylan Communications' third birthday party at The Nine: Moylan Communications' Tom Moylan, Lana Lile, Andrew Antenucci, Nguyen Nguyen and Alec Vida; POLITICO's Sebastian Starcevic, Gerardo Fortuna and Mari Eccles; European Commission's Nathalie Vandystadt and Essi Pekonen; Caitlin Griffith from the U.K. mission; UNIFE's Ben Cuzzupe; Eurofound's Ian McCafferty; and Victoria Henderson from Cronos.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz's plans to call out Russia over the Leipzig attack are likely to have huge political consequences at home and abroad.

Paris: Now that Olivier Faure has confirmed he'll stand in the left's presidential primary , others are weighing their own bids, including investment banker Matthieu Pigasse.

London: Andy Burnham's government is facing fresh questions about its prisoner early-release scheme , while the Tories are reshuffling their shadow Cabinet.

Washington: The first mail ballots for November's midterms are due to be sent out this week — but there's a legal cloud looming over the voting method.

Canberra: Anthony Albanese heads to the Pacific Islands Forum amid growing concern about China's influence in the region.

AGENDA

— EU defense ministers hold an informal meeting until Sept. 1 in Wicklow, Ireland. Chaired by EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas.

— Bled Strategic Forum in Slovenia. Opening ceremony at 1:30 p.m. Speakers include Slovenian Prime Minister Janez Janša; Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš; Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar; Croatian Prime Minister Andrej Plenković; Slovak President Peter Pellegrini; the EU's Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica; and Venezuelan opposition leader and 2025 Nobel Peace Prize winner María Corina Machado. Full program . Watch the livestream .

— Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra gives a keynote speech at the opening of the academic year at TU Delft in the Netherlands. Watch .

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives a visitor group presenting a youth paper on the Circular Economy Act.

— NATO Deputy Secretary-General Radmila Shekerinska begins a two-day visit to Dublin and participates in an event hosted by the Institute of International and European Affairs at 2:30 p.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Ondřej Knotek and Tonino Picula; former MEPs Lefteris Christoforou, Massimo Casanova, Herbert Reul and Janice Atkinson; Matthieu Hébert, head of unit at the Commission's DG ECFIN; Hydrogen Europe's Laurent Donceel; ICF Next's Mathilde Ciocci; European Commission's Richard Coxon.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from AMD: Europe is in a decisive phase in the race to shape its AI future. Building infrastructure that will reinforce long-term autonomy, resilience and competitiveness is an imperative. Choices made now influence who retains leverage, how quickly Europe can respond to change and where the value created by AI ultimately resides. Systems built on open standards and interoperability give institutions, researchers and enterprises the freedom to adapt, integrate new capabilities and avoid dependence on any single technology path. Supplier diversity strengthens that equation by reducing concentration risk and supporting a more resilient innovation ecosystem. A competitive AI ecosystem depends on an open technology stack that enables choice across hardware, software and deployment models.****

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